Fight Evil with Poetry

with poems by Dick Westheimer and Yoram Symons

INTRODUCTION

The war in Gaza, particularly the loss of civilian lives, has led to a questioning of Israel's actions and a sense of disconnect for some Jews who initially supported Israel's response. Poet Dick Westheimer explains: "I am shocked by news from the Middle East -- from the evictions of Palestinians from Sheikh Jarrah to the raids on the al-Aqsa mosque to the Hamas rockets cascading indiscriminately on Israeli cities to the massive reprisals -- resulting in incalculable suffering -- launched against Gaza. Like many American Jews I am torn between my desire to see a secure Israeli/Jewish state and the horror of seeing my fellow Jews forsake fundamentally Jewish values." -- Tikkun Olam (repairing the world), Tzedakah (righteous giving) and Chesed (loving-kindness).

An American Jew Fails to Make Sense of the Carnage in Gaza by Dick Westheimer

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Four-year-old Sarah of Gaza can't feel her legs. Her brother
can't forget the roof falling. Their father, Zahir
can't find a way to help either of them and I can't stop

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crying -- anymore than I can stop being a Jew, anymore
than I can forget the hunger that claws at my gut on a fast day,
anymore than I can stop a building from collapsing
on a child in Gaza.

Out my window, I see a red-winged blackbird harrying
a vulture who can't stop being a vulture set upon by a blackbird
who can't help being a blackbird harassing a vulture
who can't stop eying the mamma-bird's
gape-mouthed nestlings.

I am neither vulture nor red-wing. Nor am I a Jew
at least according to Genesis 1:26 which says on the sixth day
God created humans -- nothing about Palestinians and Jews
and line 21 didn't say on the fifth day God created
blackbirds and buzzards -- just nonspecific winged things.
Yet I see in the trees outside my window --
one Biblically unspecified species that can't resist
tormenting another.

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Making sense of the never-ending contest among
our tribes by counting dead Gazans and Israelis
is like trying to understand the Bible
by counting its words then dividing
by the pieces of shrapnel lodged in little Sarah's spine
or the tally of rockets that rained on Israel last week
or the count of families fearing eviction from Sheikh Jarrah
or the sum of all Arabs driven from their homes
or Jews from theirs or the two fingers, blackened and scarred,
Sarah raises, smiling as she says to the reporter,
"I am strong."

But here we are, smile and shrapnel, blackbird and buzzard,
the fifth day and the sixth -- and then the seventh when God said:
you guys figure it out.
We didn't.

Which is ironic because my tribe worked out a lot -- like
"welcome the stranger" and "love thy neighbor" and don't covet
or murder or lie about anyone. We did just fine except
for the times it felt like every person in the world
wanted to burn us or drive us away. Yet,

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as soon as we found refuge in a land already inhabited,
built that place in our own image, we turned into
a covetous sort.

Tonight at Shabbat, my four-year-old grandson Jude, dressed in lavender,
twirls and tumbles about the room, sparks like stars in the candlelight.
I recall a video of Sarah from the day before the bombs fell.
She shows off her pink Eid dress, her eyes smile deep chocolate brown
like Jude's. I turn away and dream of a future:
At a feast, I am arm-in-arm with Zahir
as our two dancers swirl in a blur of scarves,
purple and pink.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Dick Westheimer
Web link: https://rattle.com/an-american-jew-fails-to-make-sense-of-the-carnage-in-gaza-by-dick-westheimer/
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TRANSITION

*The Israel-Hamas war includes many **if only's**:*
***If only** Hamas had not rampaged across Israel's southern border to torture, murder and kidnap on Oct. 7, 2023; **if only** Hamas had not cynically placed their fighters, command centers and weaponry in crowded civilian centers; **if only** the leaders on both sides could agree on a ceasefire; **if only** Jewish people living abroad weren't facing increasing levels of antisemitism as a direct result of decisions over which they have no control . . .*

I am a Jew by Yoram Symons

I Am A Jew By Yoram Symons

I am a Jew

And, sometimes

I am afraid

to admit

that I'm a Jew

So, sometimes

I just sit

And admit

Nothing.

You can hide the Jew.

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Jew isn't a skin colour.

What's your name?

Yoram I say

That's an interesting name. Where's it from?

It's Jewish

I wanna say

Ought to say

Should say

But don't say

So instead I say

It's from the Bible. Towards the back.

And then change the topic of conversation.

Because you can hide the Jew.

Jew isn't a skin colour.

My fear is this.

I get up in public spaces

In front of all the anticipating faces

To reveal vulnerability and existentiality

But then from the back somewhere

Someone suddenly screams:

F**** you Jew!

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Why are you murdering Palestinian babies?

Look at you,

Standing up there on a stage

While you oppress an entire people,

Grind them under your colonial boot,

Murder their children,

Massacre their babies,

Demolish their homes and

Steal their land and

Systematically

Systematically

Systematically

Deny their existence as a people,

Deny their right to their own homeland,

Deny that they are even suffering at all,

And on top of it all

To cry to the world

That you are the victim.

F*** you Jew.

So what do I say?

What should I say?

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I ought to say:

F***the Government of Israel!

I recognize

Your dirty lies

Your apartheid

And your genocide

But by the time I get home

By the time I get home

And check my facebook feed

It begins:

How dare you?

Betray your own people!

Haven't we suffered enough?

All those generations

Died for you

And now you throw it in their faces

Coward

Traitor

Self-hating Jew-hater.

Don't you understand?

They want to kill us Murder us

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Throw us into the sea

Smash us

Gas us

Make us bleed

Seventy years of Israel with a gun to our heads

And you want the holocaust

To happen to us

Again?

We are murdering human beings!

They are animals!

We invaded their land

It's not theirs, it's ours!

We are doing to them what was done to us

Shut up! Shut up!

There is NO comparison

There IS SO a comparison

There is NO comparison!

SHUT UP!

SHUT UP!

SHUT UP.

Shut up

Shut up

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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